The Winning Product Research Bible

GPLMart - practical digital resources for ecommerce sellers, developers and creators.

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Chapter 1 - The product research mindset

What makes a "winning" product

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The #1 mistake: chasing "trending" products

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Research vs guessing

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Guessing: "I think phone stands will sell"
Research: "Search volume is X, competition is Y, margin is Z, trending angle is W"


Every product decision should have data behind it. This book gives you the data sources
and the validation framework.

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## Chapter 2 - Where to find product ideas (the sources)

### Trend sources (what's moving NOW)

| Source | What it shows | How to use |
|---|---|---|
| TikTok Creative Center | Trending products/videos by region | Filter India + your
target markets, sort by trending |
| Facebook Ad Library | What competitors are advertising | Search product categories,
see what's scaling |
| Amazon Best Sellers | Proven demand categories | Look at Movers & Shakers for rising
products |
| Pinterest Trends | Visual product trends | Seasonal + evergreen ideas |
| Google Trends | Search interest over time | Rising queries in your niche |

### Evergreen sources (always in demand)
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- Amazon bestsellers in your category
- AliExpress/CJ Dropshipping "hot products"
- Shopify app store bestsellers (apps that solve problems = product opportunities)
- Your own customers: what do they ask for? what do they buy together?

The niche strategy

Don't sell "everything". Pick a niche you understand or can research deeply:

- **Broad**: "home and kitchen" (too competitive)
- **Niche**: "lunch boxes for office workers who care about health" (focused, ownable)

Niche stores convert better, have cheaper ads (smaller audience to target), and build loyalty faster.

Chapter 3 - Demand validation (is anyone actually buying?)

The 5-question demand test

For every product idea, answer:

1. **Search volume**: Are people searching for it? (Google Keyword Planner, free)
2. **Sales evidence**: Are competitors selling it? How many reviews/sales visible?
3. **Trend direction**: Is interest rising, stable, or declining? (Google Trends)
4. **Seasonality**: Does it spike and die, or sell year-round?
5. **Price point**: Is the price range where impulse buys happen (¹199-1999)?

Validation tools (free)

- **Google Trends**: search product term !’ see interest over 5 years, related queries, regional interest
- **Amazon Movers & Shakers**: products gaining sales rank fastest
- **Facebook Ad Library**: are stores advertising this product? (if yes, it's probably profitable)
- **TikTok Creative Center**: trending products in your region
- **AliExpress/CJ "hot" sections**: what's suppliers pushing (often correlates with demand)

The "5 competitors" rule

Before committing to a product, find 5 stores already selling it successfully. If you can't find 5, demand may not exist. If you find 50+, it's saturated - pick a sub-niche or skip.

Chapter 4 - Competition analysis (can you actually win?)

Competition levels

Level	Signal	Strategy
Low	Few sellers, weak listings	Enter fast, be first-mover
Medium	Several sellers, mixed quality	Compete on price/marketing/niche
High	Many sellers, strong brands	Need strong differentiation or skip
Saturated	Amazon/private labels dominate	Skip unless you have unique angle

What to analyze in competitors

- **Pricing**: what's the price range? can you compete on margin?
- **Listings**: are they good or lazy? (bad listings = your opportunity)
- **Reviews**: how many? what do customers complain about? (your opening)
- **Marketing**: are they running ads? what creative? (validate demand + learn angles)
- **Fulfilment**: shipping times, return policy (your advantage if faster/better)

Finding your edge

You don't need to be cheapest. You need ONE advantage:

- Better photos/content
- Faster shipping
- Better price
- Niche focus ("for diabetics" vs "for everyone")
- Better customer service (WhatsApp, fast replies)
- Bundle/kit offering

Chapter 5 - Margin math (the numbers that kill products)

The real margin formula

```
Real margin = Selling price
            - Product cost
            - Shipping cost (to customer)
            - Payment gateway fees (~2%)
            - Packaging cost
            - Returns/RTO reserve (15-30% of orders for COD)
            - Ad spend per order (if running ads)
```

Margin targets

Margin	Verdict
<20%	Too thin - one bad month kills you
20-30%	Workable but tight - need volume
30-45%	Healthy - room for ads and mistakes
45%+	Excellent - can scale aggressively

The shipping trap (India-specific)

Shipping kills margins on cheap products:

- ₹199 product + ₹80 shipping = customer pays ₹279, you net ₹199 minus fees
- Solution: bundles (higher cart value = shipping feels smaller), free shipping threshold, or products ₹499+

Example margin calculation

```
Product: Steel lunch box
Product cost: ₹280 (CJ Dropshipping)
Shipping to customer: ₹60
Payment fees: 2% of ₹599 = ₹12
Packaging: ₹15
Returns reserve (20% RTO): ₹120 x 0.20 = ₹24

Selling price: ₹599
Real margin = 599 - 280 - 60 - 12 - 15 - 24 = ₹208 = 35% margin '
```

Chapter 6 - Sourcing: where to actually get products

India sourcing

Source	Best for	Notes
IndiaMART	Domestic products, bulk	Verify supplier, order samples
Udaan	B2B wholesale	Good for fashion, home, beauty
Local manufacturers	Custom/private label	Higher MOQ, better margins long-term
Meesho supplier catalog	Reseller model	Low entry, lower margins

International sourcing (dropshipping)

Source	Best for	Shipping to India
CJ Dropshipping	General products	7-15 days, good for testing
AliExpress	Cheap products	10-20 days, quality varies
Zendrop/Spocket	US/EU focus	Faster shipping, higher cost
SaleHoo	Verified suppliers	Directory, not direct supplier

Sourcing checklist

- [ ] Order sample to yourself FIRST (always - photos lie)
- [ ] Check supplier rating/reviews on platform
- [ ] Confirm shipping time to YOUR customer (not just to you)
- [ ] Check return policy (who pays return shipping?)
- [ ] Verify product quality matches listing photos

- [ ] Check if supplier has other sellers (competition check)
- [ ] Calculate landed cost (product + shipping + customs if applicable)

Chapter 7 - The validation framework (before you commit)

The 10-point product scorecard

Rate each 1-5, total out of 50:

Criteria	Score
Demand evidence (searches, sales)	/5
Trend direction (rising/stable)	/5
Competition beatability	/5
Margin potential (35%+ target)	/5
Shipping reliability	/5
Return rate expectation (low)	/5
Marketing angle exists	/5
Audience you can reach	/5
Supplier quality/reliability	/5
Your interest/knowledge	/5

Score interpretation:
- 40-50: Strong candidate - test with small budget
- 30-39: Promising - needs more validation
- Below 30: Skip or keep researching

The small test (before full launch)

Don't launch 15 products blindly. Test 3-5:

- List them with basic listings
- Run ¹500-1000 Meta ads test per product (5-7 days)
- Measure: clicks, add-to-carts, purchases, CPA
- Winners get full listings + more ads
- Losers get delisted or improved

This costs ¹3,000-5,000 but saves you months of selling the wrong products.

Chapter 8 - Seasonal vs evergreen strategy

Evergreen products (sell year-round)

- Kitchen/storage, phone accessories, fitness, pet products, office supplies
- Steady demand, predictable - foundation of your store
- Aim for 60-70% of your catalog

Seasonal products (spike at times)

- Diwali gifts, summer products, back-to-school, wedding season
- Higher margins possible, but demand is time-limited
- Plan 4-6 weeks ahead - sourcing + listing takes time
- Aim for 20-30% of catalog

Trend products (risky, high reward)

- Viral TikTok products, fad items
- Can make quick money but saturate fast
- Only enter if you can move FAST (list within days of trend)
- Keep inventory/orders flexible - don't stock deep

Chapter 9 - International vs India product research

Selling in India

- Focus: value-for-money, COD-friendly, WhatsApp support
- Price points: ¹199-1999 impulse/mid-range
- Research: Amazon India bestsellers, Meesho trending, Flipkart
- Competition: high but market is huge

Selling internationally (US/EU)

- Focus: quality perception, faster shipping expectations, higher prices

- Price points: $15-50 typical
- Research: Amazon US bestsellers, TikTok Shop trends, Shopify stores
- Competition: different - need stronger branding/differentiation
- Shipping: CJ/Spocket/Zendrop for faster delivery
- Payments: Stripe/PayPal + local payment methods

Cross-border considerations

- Customs/duties can kill margins on cheap products shipped far
- Returns are expensive internationally - product quality matters more
- Language/cultural fit: product must make sense to target market
- Payment methods: UPI/COD essential for India, cards/PayPal for US/EU

Chapter 10 - The product research workflow (weekly system)

Weekly research routine (2-3 hours)

1. **Scan trends** (30 min): TikTok Creative Center, Facebook Ad Library, Amazon Movers
2. **Pick 3-5 ideas** that match your niche/audience
3. **Validate demand** (30 min): Google Trends, competitor check, search volume
4. **Check margins** (30 min): product cost + shipping + fees = real margin
5. **Source & sample** (ongoing): order samples for top candidates
6. **Score & decide** (15 min): scorecard, pick winners for testing

Monthly review

- Which products are actually selling? (data > opinions)
- Which have best margin? (double down)
- Which have high returns? (fix or drop)
- What's the competitor doing differently? (learn or beat)

Chapter 11 - Product research red flags (skip these)

- **Too cheap to ship profitably**: product cost + shipping > 60% of price
- **High return category**: clothing sizing issues, fragile items, perishables
- **IP/trademark risk**: branded products, copyrighted designs, patent issues
- **Oversaturated with no angle**: 100+ sellers, all identical listings
- **Supplier can't provide samples**: quality is a gamble
- **Shipping takes 30+ days**: customers won't wait, returns spike
- **No clear use case**: "cool gadget" without problem it solves

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Chapter 12 - Your product research notebook (template)

For every product you research, fill this:

```
PRODUCT: [name]
SOURCE: [where found - TikTok/Amazon/CJ/etc]
DATE: [research date]

DEMAND:
- Search volume: [high/medium/low]
- Competitors selling: [count]
- Trend: [rising/stable/declining]

MARGIN:
- Product cost:  [$]
- Shipping:  [$]
- Fees: ~[$]
- Target price:  [$]
- Real margin: [%]

COMPETITION:
- Top competitor price:  [$]
- Their advantage: [photos/price/ads/niche]
- Your edge: [what you'll do differently]

SOURCING:
- Supplier: [name/platform]
- Sample ordered: [yes/no/date]
- Shipping time: [days]
- Return policy: [terms]
```

```
SCORECARD TOTAL: [X/50]
DECISION: [test/skip/more research]
```

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